

reach Tokyo, a two-day journey, stopping three times for fuel. And most of these long-distance flights could be made with minimal risk. Transcontinental and transoceanic flight had ceased to be an heroic enterprise.

The romance of the “heroic age” of aviation had required an awesome waste of young lives. The list of those lost pushing the limits of speed or distance included the famous – Jean Mermoz, Wiley Post, Charles Kingsford Smith, Amelia Earhart, James Wedell, Bert Hinkler, Harry Hawker – and hundreds whose names were unknown to the public or have long since been forgotten. Without the high risks, the drama of flight could never have reached the pitch that

enthralled the public and made the likes of Lindbergh and Earhart into legends of solitary endeavor.

But while the deeds of individual pilots occupied the front of the public stage, flight was being adopted by governments and large corporations as a business interest and a projection of national power and prestige. It was becoming a serious matter of concern for government bureaucracies, official research institutes, commercial interests, and military establishments, and as a result both a safe and reliable form of transportation and an increasingly effective weapon of war. By the late 1930s, the image of flight as a realm in which heroic individuals pitted their courage and skill against the elements was going out of date.



WORLD'S LONGEST AIR RACE

Miss Clara Johnson, a United Air Lines stewardess, points to an artwork on the Boeing 247D that took part in the 1934 MacRobertson London-to-Melbourne Air Race. The Boeing came in third; the race was won by a de Havilland Comet.



FLIGHT OF THE CONDOR

This four-engine Focke-Wulf Fw 200 Condor transport plane is shown being welcomed home at Tempelhof Airport, Berlin. The Condor's nonstop flight from Berlin to New York in 24½ hours on August 11, 1938, gave proof of the capabilities of Germany's renaissance air industry.